

SAMIA SINGH

Take the typical sounds from a simple South Indian café in Matunga, Mumbai. Stir in some musical genius. And you have sound art that's being showcased at a first-of-its-kind sound art gallery Le Son 7 in New York's Soho, and which global buyers are bidding for. Trust musician-producer Talvin Singh, known as the father of modern Asian electronic music, to be at the cutting edge of creativity! Singh tells us about this piece titled *Vada*, which has audiophiles vying to own it. "So, on one visit to Mumbai, I had used a Sony professional recorder to capture the sounds at the back of the kitchen, where they were washing a sink full of steel plates and shouting out to each other. I kept that recording close to me all these years. My piece has a sample of that. And then the very abstract sound of bells and temple bells too," he says, trying to describe the medley of the sizzle of a vada frying in hot oil, conversations and chimes. With this pathbreaking piece now travelling to South America, other sound installations being conceptualised, studying the surbahar under the tutelage of the guru who taught him tabla when he was 16—Ustad Lachman Singh Seen of the Punjab gharana—and a much-awaited new Asian Underground album being released in August 2024 (a new solo one after almost two decades), Singh is clearly on a roll. He will be performing

PLAY

THE GUJARATI MONOLOGUES

***After performing over 1,000 shows, actor* Mahabanoo Mody-Kotwal *now brings us a Gujarati version of* The Vagina Monologues**

Mahabanoo Mody-Kotwal wholeheartedly embraces the moniker of 'The Vagina Lady' of India. She's earned it after having performed over 1,000 shows of *The Vagina Monologues* over two decades, in English and Hindi. Nearing 80, Kotwal isn't done with V's (formerly Eve Ensler) iconic play which oscillates between female desire and pleasure to sexual violence with effortless ease. Kotwal returns to the high chair this time with a Gujarati adaptation, written in collaboration with Chirantana Bhatt and featuring Swati Das, Kruttika Desai, R.J. Devaki and Girija Oak in the cast. The idea that India would be the only country to perform the play in three languages appealed to the Parsi theatre artist. She isn't worried about the play's reception with a new audience. "Gujarati theatre is very forward thinking," she says, "and its audience is very savvy. I don't see why people would find vagina provocative. It needs to be revered, there's nothing shameful about it. What's shameful is that it is used by men to abuse women."

Kotwal says they have kept the emotional quotient of the play intact, but where they have "played a bit" is with the context. While adapting, Bhatt brought in "different flavours" of the language. Says Bhatt, "The tone and speed of speaking is different. I've tried to incorporate those variations, which is

